at the same time," said our grandmother, pressing her stretched legs. (Our paati was extremely fond of her legs. She was forever stroking them.)

At that moment, our maternal uncle, Maamanaar, walked in. Pedanna ran and brought the stool. For a while, the whole house **spluttered** into giggles before things settled down.

Maamanaar himself had chosen a spot to sit whenever he visited our house. Chop off his head, and he'd still sit there and nowhere else. He would lean against the pillar adjoining the wall to the south of the storeroom. The first thing he would do as soon as he sat down was to loosen his tuft, give it a good shake, scratch his head and tie it back tightly. He observed this ritual unfailingly. Then he would inspect the floor around him. "Didn't see any money falling from your head," Anna would say with an **impudent** smile.

He would always be pierced with such paper arrows whenever he visited us. He would sit mum with a smile, like a stone Pillaiyaar, as if to say, "You are my relatives—if you don't tease me, who will?" When our ridicule overstepped the limits, Amma would pretend to chide us. The last word always ended in "you donkeys".

As soon as Maamanaar sat down, Amma went towards the kitchen. Like a lamb, Appa followed her. In a while Amma appeared in the passage, a silver tumbler of buttermilk seasoned with asafoetida in her hand, followed by Appa, who, unseen by her, aped her movements for our benefit, as if to say, "Her brother has come, it seems. Look at her taking buttermilk for him with so much care." The aroma of the buttermilk and the asafoetida made us want to drink it right away.

We believed that Maamanaar visited us mainly to drink buttermilk. The buttermilk from our cow was that divine. Besides, we thought that our uncle was the stingiest person in the village. We firmly believed he never gave away anything to anyone.

He himself had gone to Kannaavaram to buy this famed black-tongued milchcow for his sister. My younger brother and sister doted on its calf. Whenever he came over, and just before he left, he always went around the cow, gave it a pat (he was afraid his own evil eye would fall on it!), and uttered words of praise, even if he was thrifty with them. My little siblings always had this big fear that once the milk dried up, the cow would be taken away to his house, along with the calf.

The anticipation of this imagined separation only increased their fondness for the calf and their bitterness towards Maamanaar. Whenever he relished the buttermilk, these small children punched and pinched with their very stares.

Maamanaar showed interest in the debate about the chair. He let it be known that he too would like one to be made for him. We too were glad to have a partner in this enterprise.

Maamanaar said that the neem tree was the best. It would keep the body cool.

When he **expounded** on the neem tree, Appa looked at him with round-eyed astonishment. Only the day before Appa had been talking to a farmhand about cutting down an ancient, diamond-hard



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